

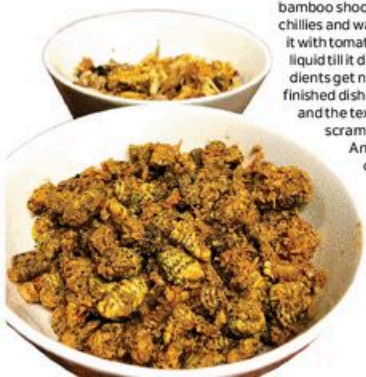
POKKALI RICE DISHES, KERALA

Saline-resistant, climate-adapting, and tall, Pokkali is a rice that is native to Kerala. "It is extremely wholesome, flavourful and versatile," says Zacharias. He tried this variant at Thekkanatt, the farm of Hormis Tharakan and his wife Molly. He remembers eating it plain boiled, in *appams*, *puttu*, and *idiappams*. "Visiting the farm, understanding the process and challenges of cultivating the rice, and ending it with a meal makes you appreciate the ingredients a lot more," he says. The farm grows rice for half the year and cultivates prawns for the remaining six months, in the interest of commercial viability.



MEPFIGHA, NAGALAND

In 2018, a visit to Khonoma, India's first green village in Nagaland, introduced the chef to a first: bee larvae. He ate Mepfigha, bee larvae cooked with tomatoes, shredded *bastenga* (fermented bamboo shoot), ginger, garlic, chillies and water. "They cook it with tomatoes, reducing the liquid till it dries up, so the ingredients get nicely browned. The finished dish has a nutty flavour and the texture and taste of scrambled eggs," he says. Another interesting dish he ate on that trip was *lulu*: silk worms cut in half and cooked with garlic, bamboo shoot water and Naga chilli.



DONNE OR SUVA BHAKRI, GOA

On his trip to Goa, Zacharias tried a different form of the sweet dish *patoli*. "Donne is a typical snack among the Velip community. It has rice dough with a coconut jaggery filling, shaped into a cone, and steamed inside jackfruit leaves," he says. Jackfruit leaves add flavour, and impart a lovely design to the dough. The community also uses the local *madachem godh* (coconut jaggery).

Zacharias first tasted this at Cotigao, at the home of Devidas Gaonkar, a member of the Velip tribe who has been documenting the oral history of his tribe. "I saw it made from scratch. There's some skill involved in shaping the leaves, kneading the dough to the right consistency, and choosing the right ratio of dough to filling. Also, it is important to eat it when still hot," he says.